

What to charge, and why it's sustainable

Ten direct comparables benchmarked against VitaLinks' actual cost to serve — not estimated, computed from the real Firestore sync architecture and the exact Anthropic model the app calls today. The recommendation below is priced to leave healthy margin even in the worst case.

RECOMMENDATION

Two tiers, priced for an unproven app

Core tracking stays free forever — that's the north star's "local-first" promise, and most of the comparables set (Cronometer, Strava) prove a generous free tier is compatible with a real paid tier. The paid tier's entire value proposition is removing the API-key friction, priced right at what that convenience actually costs us.

Free

€0

- ✓ All current tracking: meals, exercise, blood pressure, medications, body composition, weight forecasting
- ✓ Personalized meals, 30-day PDF clinician report, progress sharing, invites
- ✓ AI calorie estimation — bring your own Anthropic API key
- ✓ Full cross-device sync

No feature is held back from free users — only the AI convenience is gated, and only because it has a real marginal cost.

RECOMMENDED PAID TIER

VitaLinks Plus

€6.99 / month

or €49.99/year (€4.17/mo effective — 40% off monthly) · \$7.99/mo · \$54.99/yr in USD markets

- ✓ AI calorie estimation included — no API key needed, up to 15 estimates/day
- ✓ Everything in Free
- ✓ "Founder" pricing: locked for as long as the subscription stays active, even after standard pricing rises

Priced below Cronometer Gold (€10.99/mo) and MyFitnessPal Premium (€24.99/mo) — deliberately, given zero brand trust today. See "why these numbers" below.

Computed from the live codebase, not a generic SaaS cost model.

AI COST PER ESTIMATE

\$0.0026

Claude Sonnet 4.6 · ~270 in / ~120 out tokens, priced at the model's real API rate

PLUS TIER AI COST, WORST CASE

\$1.17/mo

15 calls/day × 30 days, every single day — the ceiling, not the average

NET MARGIN, REALISTIC CASE

~70%

After AI cost + a 15% store fee — the expected case for both stores at launch scale

Anthropic API — the AI-estimate feature

The app's `estimateNutrition()` prompt is small and structured — a short nutritionist instruction plus a fixed JSON schema, run against `claude-sonnet-4-6` at \$3/MTok input and \$15/MTok output. That's roughly 270 input tokens and 120 output tokens per call:

DAILY CAP	COST/DAY (FULL USE)	COST/MONTH (FULL USE)	NOTES
5 / day	\$0.013	\$0.39	Feels limiting for someone logging 3 meals
15 / day	\$0.039	\$1.17	Recommended — generous for realistic daily logging, still bounded
30 / day	\$0.078	\$2.34	No real UX benefit over 15/day for a personal tracker; mainly raises abuse risk

Real-world cost will run below this table

Every estimate first checks the user's own history, then the **shared public food bank** before ever calling the API — a food only costs an API call the first time *anyone* logs it. The \$1.17/mo figure assumes zero cache hits, which won't hold once the shared bank has any depth to it.

There's also a live cost lever available today: **Claude Sonnet 5** now prices at \$2/\$10 per MTok versus Sonnet 4.6's \$3/\$15 — switching the model string would cut this cost by roughly a third with no other code change.

Firestore — the sync database

VitaLinks syncs each user as a **single Firestore document** — one write per debounced change, one read per connected device per change — rather than a row per logged item. That shape is unusually cheap:

SCALE	EST. WRITES/MO	EST. READS/MO	MONTHLY FIRESTORE COST
Today (dozens of users)	< 20K	< 50K	\$0.00 — inside Firebase's free daily quota
1,000 active users	~450K	~450K	\$0.00 — still inside the free 600K writes / 1.5M reads per month
10,000 active users	~4.5M	~4.5M	~\$7-10/mo at \$0.18/100K writes, \$0.06/100K reads (Blaze pay-as-you-go, multi-region)

The real risk isn’t cost — it’s a hard document-size ceiling

Every synced day ever logged accumulates into that one user document forever (nothing is pruned or archived). Firestore caps a single document at **1 MiB**. A light user won't notice for years; a daily power-user's account could approach that ceiling in a multi-year timeframe, at which point sync doesn't get more expensive — **it starts failing outright**.

This isn't a pricing lever, it's an engineering item: worth splitting into per-day (or per-month) subcollection documents before the app has users old enough to hit it. Flagging here because it surfaced directly from modeling the cost, not because it changes today's numbers.

App Store & Play Store fees

Both platforms restructured subscription commissions recently, and both land in the same place for an app at VitaLinks' scale — well below the 30% headline rate most people assume:

PATH	EFFECTIVE RATE	WHY VITALINKS QUALIFIES
Apple, Small Business Program	15%	Automatic for any developer under \$1M/yr in App Store proceeds — from day one, any subscriber tenure
Apple, EU alternative terms, year 2+	10%	Further reduction Apple offers EU developers on subscriptions past a subscriber's first year
Google Play, standard billing	15%	10% service fee + 5% billing fee, effective June 2026 in the US/UK/EEA — replaces the old 15%/30% tiered model for subscriptions

Google Play, alternative billing	10%	Service fee only, no billing fee — available where alternative payment methods are permitted (EEA included)
Direct/web billing (Stripe-like)	~3%	VitaLinks is a web app first — a subscription started on vitalinks.eu itself bypasses store commission entirely

SCENARIO	FEE	NET AFTER AI COST + FEE	MARGIN
Direct/web billing	~3%	\$6.29	~79%
Store, realistic case (15%)	15%	\$5.62	~70%
Store, EU reduced rate (10%)	10%	\$6.02	~75%
Store, non-qualifying ceiling (30%)	30%	\$4.42	~55%

The price holds up under every scenario

Even the worst case most people budget for by default — 30%, as if VitaLinks didn't qualify for any reduced-fee program — still clears **55% margin** at \$7.99/mo. The realistic case (both stores converge near 15% for an app this size) lands at **~70%**, a healthy software margin by any standard. No reason to price higher just to defend against store fees; enrolling in Apple's Small Business Program and using standard Play billing is enough.

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Why these numbers, not the comparables’ numbers

Direct nutrition-tracking apps cluster tightly; adjacent categories widen the range.

APP	FREE TIER	MONTHLY	ANNUAL	ANNUAL DISCOUNT
Cronometer Gold	Full logging, 84 nutrients, 7-day report window	\$10.99	\$59.99	~55%
MyFitnessPal Premium	Basic logging, ads	\$19.99	\$79.99	~67%
Lose It! Premium	Basic logging	annual-only	\$79.99	—

Strava Individual	Full social feed & activity recording	\$11.99	\$79.99	~44%
Headspace	Limited content library	\$12.99	\$69.99	~55%
Calm	Limited content library	\$14.99	\$69.99	~55–61%
Fitbit / Google Health Premium	Steps, HR, basic sleep stages	\$9.99	\$99.99	~17% (narrowed sharply in a 2026 repricing)
Noom	None — trial only	\$70 (quiz-personalized, highly variable)	~\$209	~75% (noisy — promo-driven pricing)
Levels / Nutrisense (CGM, reference only)	None	\$24–\$249 depending on tier	\$288–\$1,999	clinical ceiling, not a peer

Reading the pattern

Direct comparables (nutrition-depth apps) sit at \$10–20/mo, \$60–80/yr, 55–67% annual discount.

Cronometer is the closest peer in scope; VitaLinks already matches or exceeds its tracking depth (body composition, medications, weight forecasting, and a clinician PDF report Cronometer doesn't offer).

VitaLinks Plus at €6.99/mo prices deliberately below that cluster — not because the product is worth less, but because an unlaunched app with zero reviews and zero brand trust has to earn the first subscribers before it can charge peer rates. Every comparable above spent years building the trust that justifies \$11–20/mo; VitaLinks hasn't shipped to a store yet.

The "Founder" framing (locked-in pricing for early subscribers, even as list price rises later) is a documented pattern for exactly this situation — it converts the disadvantage of being unknown into a visible reward for being early, rather than just discounting silently.

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What we'd revisit, and when

- 1 After the first real cohort of Plus subscribers: check actual AI calls/user/day against the 15/day assumption — raise or lower the cap based on real usage, not the modeled ceiling.
- 2 Before any account crosses ~2 years of daily logging: revisit the Firestore document-size architecture, independent of pricing.

- 3 During M2 store setup: actually enroll in Apple's Small Business Program (it isn't automatic) and confirm Google Play's June 2026 fee restructuring still applies once live — both assumptions above depend on it.
- 4 If/when the Social or Psycho pillars ship real paid features: reconsider whether Plus stays a single tier or splits, rather than folding new value into the same €6.99 price by default.

Methodology: comparable pricing gathered live (late Aug 2026) from vendor pricing pages where fetchable, cross-checked against secondary trackers where blocked. AI cost computed from the actual `estimateNutrition()` prompt and Anthropic's published API pricing for `claude-sonnet-4-6`. Firestore cost computed from the actual `collectLocalData()` / `pushToCloud()` sync pattern in `index.html` against Firebase's published Blaze-plan free quotas and per-operation rates. Store fees reflect Apple's Small Business Program terms and Google Play's subscription fee restructuring effective June 30, 2026 (10% service fee + 5% billing fee in the US/UK/EEA, or 10% alone on alternative billing) — both gathered live and current as of this report's date, not the general 15–30% assumption most sources default to.